9

FIRST AS TRAGEDY, THEN AS FARCE

MANAGING THE US WITHDRAWAL

'U.S. and its partners must recognise that they are in Afghanistan for the long haul and that if the U.S. did not persevere, Islamist groups would be even further emboldened ... [and] until the Pakistan military had made this commitment [eliminating all terror groups on its territory], the U.S. would be fighting a losing battle in Afghanistan.'

Manmohan Singh, PM of India to US Senator John Kerry, December 2008[1]

'One of our regrets has been that India was a passive player with regards to America's intervention in Afghanistan. I just couldn't believe that there wasn't that much strategic consultation and interaction between India and the US on Afghanistan. In fact, I was the one who facilitated the first trilateral engagement between the three countries [in 2012] and I realised in that meeting how distant the two countries were.'

Jawed Ludin, former deputy foreign minister of Afghanistan, 2013[2]

A mismatch made in heaven

It was a peculiar situation. Despite witnessing the worst historical lows in its bilateral relationship with the US, Pakistan was the most critical player in Afghanistan. In the aftermath of the 9/11 attacks the White House, the